a flagbearer of the new social coalition that the Opposition parties are gradually crafting to fight back the BJP's hegemony of the past decade. In the years to come, beyond Parliament and legislative assemblies, it is from this social coalition that incremental challenges to the BJP will come from.

Ask the Congress, and insiders will tell you that Sanjana is a culmination of the core working philosophy Rahul has been formulating for some years and which has now begun gaining currency on the ground. Following consecutive and humiliating defeats in two general elections, the Congress was perceived to be a lost cause, helpless in the face of the BJP's Hindu nationalist agenda. Nobody knew what the Congress stood for any more. "The party needed to project an idea of itself beyond the one reflected through the prism of the BJP's IT cell and the pliable media," says a Congress leader who has just won a Lok Sabha seat.

A NARRATIVE CALLED NYAY

More importantly, the Congress needed to disrupt the unbeatable electoral arithmetic the BJP had devised through deft social engineering. The saffron formation, for example, had woven a vast and colourful tapestry of a singular Hindu identity, with its core elite caste vote bank providing the warp and disgruntled sections of the Other Backward Classes, Scheduled Castes and Tribes the weft. It worked wonders in large caste-driven electorates of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. But the uniform idea of Hindutva and the aggression associated with it, often resulting in minority-bashing, was also breeding resentment among large sections of the OBCs, Dalits, tribals—besides Muslims. Even liberal Hindus perceived India's secular values to be under threat.

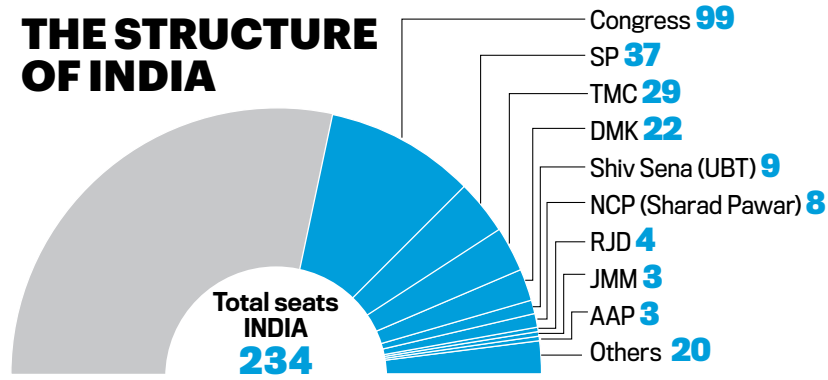
Post Covid, a large section of the population, particularly the low-income groups as well as rural folk, was getting restive because of the runaway inflation and lack of jobs. Typical of the K-shaped growth phenomenon, the country's economy was growing, but that prosperity was not percolating down to the poor. It was these veins of anguish that Rahul tapped into while drafting a new narrative for the Congress. "We had to make the people understand that the Congress stands for three things—secularism, support for the marginalised, including OBCs, SCs, STs and minorities, and pro-poor politics," reveals a close Rahul aide. The strategy seems to have come good, as the Congress improved its tally in the 131 seats reserved for SCs and STs from 10 in 2019 to 31 this time.

If his Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY) in 2022-23 was aimed at promoting love and brotherhood, rejecting the BJP's perceived politics of hatred, the Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra earlier this year was about delivering socioeconomic justice to the poor and the marginalised. "Rahul is not in a hurry to grab power," says the aide. "He wants the people to first understand what the Congress stands for." However, instead of making it a vague philosophical construct as in the past, Rahul enunciated it clearly this time, using all available tools to script his political narrative. In this script, Prime Minister Modi became the epitome of crony capitalism—with him as the benefactor and Adani as the beneficiary.

The Congress leader was also projected as a man of the people, someone who did not hesitate to join the farmers in a field, or spend time with coolies at a railway station, one who was at ease with every section of society—from IT professionals and academics to beedi workers and mechanics. He even gave glimpses into his hitherto guarded private life—be it making jam with mum Sonia or playing with his pet dog. If the BJP's IT cell cast him as a Pappu, Rahul used the same social media to present himself otherwise. "He is exactly like you see in the videos," says a close associate admiringly, "a regular guy who enjoys life beyond politics. We often find him cooking his own food."

The challenges of 2014 persist for Rahul in 2024—rebuilding the party organisation in some states, make it a winning unit in others

THE STRUCTURE OF INDIA



STRAIGHT FIGHTS

The Congress has improved its record in direct combat against the BJP, particularly because of its alliance in Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar

